

Bosnia Holds Elections as Leader Declares Victory for His Party

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Voters in Bosnia and Herzegovina went to the polls on Sunday in an election shaped by money worries, the country's hopes of joining the European Union, and long-standing divisions between ethnic groups. Those divisions date back to a war in the early 1990s.

Milorad Dodik, a Bosnian Serb **nationalist** politician, declared victory for his party. Dodik was not on the **ballot**. He was banned from public office after being convicted last year of defying decisions by the international official who oversees the 1995 peace agreement that ended the war. Even so, he has been central to the campaign. He supports Russia and has called for parts of the country to **separate**, which has made some people fear new instability.

With nearly 90 percent of votes counted, Dodik's ally Zeljka Cvijanovic had more than 55 percent for the Serb seat on Bosnia's three-member **presidency**. She led her nearest opponent by about 30 points. At a news conference, Dodik gave credit to U.S. President Donald Trump's 2024 election win and to Russian President Vladimir Putin's support. "No one should ask us to change our politics," he said.

Other candidates also claimed victory before counting was finished. They included Darijana Filipovic for the Croat seat and Denis Becirovic for the Bosniak seat, who held a lead of fewer than three percentage points. Around 3.4 million people were eligible to vote.

Bosnia's government was built by a U.S.-brokered **peace deal** to balance the Bosniak, Serb and Croat communities. Many people vote along **ethnic lines**, which has slowed progress toward joining the EU. This was the first Bosnian election to use electronic voter identification and **ballot** scanners to help prevent cheating. These are not final results.

Word Treasure

nationalist -- A person who puts strong focus on the interests of their own nation or group.

ballot -- The list of choices voters see when they vote.

separate -- To split away from a larger group or country.

presidency -- The office of president; in Bosnia it has three members.

peace deal -- An agreement that ends a war.

ethnic lines -- Divisions based on the group someone belongs to.

Break it down

Opening: the vote and the pressures behind it
Who Dodik is and why he is banned from office
Vote counts and Dodik's comments
Other candidates claiming victory
The peace deal system, ethnic voting and new technology
Closing: results are not final

Why it matters

The election shows how Bosnia's political system, built to balance different communities, still faces ethnic divisions that slow its progress toward joining the EU.

Test what you remember

1. What shaped Bosnia's Sunday election?

- ☐ (A) A big storm that closed roads
- ☐ (B) A new national flag and anthem
- ☐ (C) A change in the school year for all students
- ☐ (D) Money worries, hopes of joining the EU, and ethnic divisions

2. Why was Dodik banned from public office?

- ☐ (A) He lost an earlier election badly
- ☐ (B) He asked to leave office himself
- ☐ (C) He was convicted last year of defying an international official's decisions
- ☐ (D) He was too old to run for any office

3. How many members does Bosnia's presidency have?

- ☐ (A) One
- ☐ (B) Twelve
- ☐ (C) Three
- ☐ (D) Five

4. Who did Dodik give credit to for his party's win?

- ☐ (A) Trump's 2024 election win and Putin's support
- ☐ (B) The Bosnian army and the police
- ☐ (C) The courts in the capital Sarajevo
- ☐ (D) The European Union and the United Nations

5. Which new technology was used in this election for the first time?

- ☐ (A) Voting by phone app from home
- ☐ (B) Voting from space stations
- ☐ (C) Electronic voter identification and ballot scanners
- ☐ (D) Robot poll workers at every site

6. What made some people fear new instability?

- ☐ (A) A teachers' strike across the country
- ☐ (B) A flood in the capital city
- ☐ (C) A new tax on all goods
- ☐ (D) Dodik's pro-Russia stance and calls for parts of the country to separate

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: C 3: C 4: A 5: C 6: D

Questions to think about

1. **Milorad Dodik:** Said, "No one should ask us to change our politics," and credited Trump and Putin.
2. **People worried about instability:** Fear that his separatist rhetoric could lead to renewed instability in Bosnia.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):